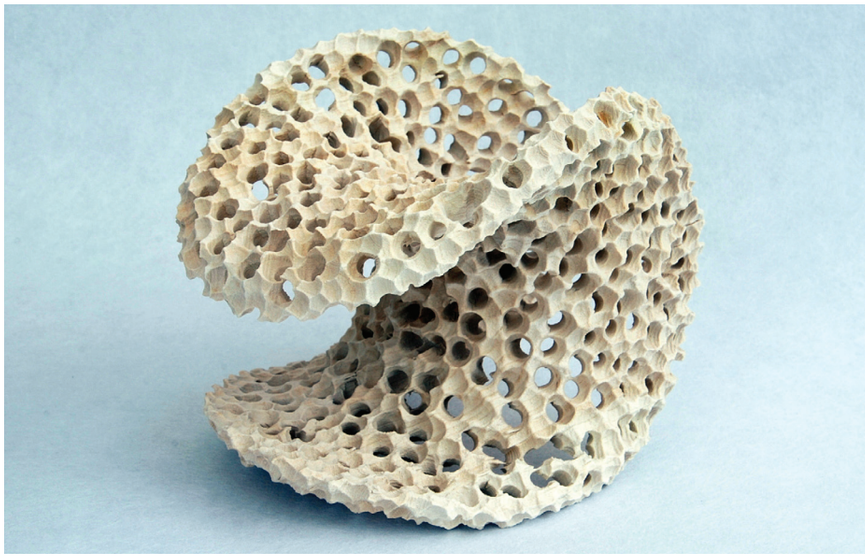
PHOTO: ANDI WOLFE

Irish Water 2



Coral Form #3

his own. This style is made up of different series he work's on, which sometimes collide or combine. Max would describe his style as exploratory, simple and geometric with Eastern influences and a bit of punk.

Two series of work Max has been working on for a while now are his 'Interconnection Forms' and his 'Bolt Forms'. The Interconnection Forms mainly consist of tubes that intersect and flow seamlessly into one another. These shapes are inspired by the beauty of geometry, something which escaped Max entirely in school. "I first tuned into this when I saw the perfect geometric patterns produced by water as it froze to ice on a local lake," Max explains.

The Bolt Forms started as an investigation into the movement and distortion of wet turned wood as it dries. The woodturner tells us his methods: "I cut apart hollow forms I had freshly turned and let the individual parts dry and distort independent of one another, before reassembling them and finding that they had moved in such different ways that they wouldn't fit back together!" Now, Max can predict with reasonable accuracy how a piece will distort as it dries and he builds this into his designs for maximum impact. Lately, he's been playing around with Interconnection Forms bolted to one another to form different geometric shapes.

Max would now describe his work in one word: 'evolving'. What he creates now is a direct result of his experiences and the way he sees the world up to this point. Max tells us he is aware there is pressure on artists and woodturners to develop a 'signature style', which makes them recognisable and although this has many advantages, Max hopes his work will have evolved into something different in a year or a decade. If it hasn't, then Max will feel he hasn't evolved as a person and a woodturner.

"Having said that," Max continues, "most of my pieces seem to be made from sandblasted, thin turned green oak, left to distort as they dry." Max feels that by distorting, even a very geometric and straight tube form takes on a more dynamic persona and comes to life. After seasoning, he sandblasts it to reveal the grain and rays, which make up the inner working of the tree.

Max thinks about how his work has developed over his woodworking career, saying: "besides the natural progression and acquisition of technical skills associated with practice, my work has changed direction from purely practical items such as furniture components and treen to conceptual work, focusing on expressing ideas and concepts."

Workshop and tools

Currently, Max's workshop is an old stone creamery building, previously used by his mother as a bakery. It has served as Max's workshop since he started making hollow wooden surfboards in 2007. It contains all of Max's furniture making machinery, lathes and mountains of 'stuff' that he hasn't sorted through in years. In the coming months, he will be moving into a larger workshop, an old boatyard across the road from the beach in the seaside village of Mullaghmore in Co. Sligo. "I'm really excited about this move," Max tells us. "From this new workshop I will run courses in woodturning for individuals and groups and courses in small wooden watercraft building."

The time Max takes to make a piece varies, but it can take from a few hours for something he's familiar and comfortable with to several days for larger, more complicated pieces that he's experimenting on for the first time.

Looking to his tools, Max tells us that he doesn't have any specialist equipment, but loves his Vicmarc lathe and chuck. Max feels it's very important for the multi-axis work he does, to have a solid and smooth lathe. He uses the 19mm Kelton hollowers because they're the simplest and most robust freehand hollowing tools he's come across.

Highs and lows

"The human condition, acceptance and rejection, winning and losing. I'd love to say I'm immune to the outside world, but ultimately when you win an award you feel high, and you feel others understand your work and when you're rejected you're

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